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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

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Research Topic：Behavioral Responses of Children Watching Theater

Keywords: Children's drama,behavioral response,concrete operational stage,social interaction,drama education

Research Problem

In Taiwan, children's theater is frequently regarded as a vital avenue for aesthetic education and social-emotional learning. Non-profit troupes regularly tour elementary schools and remote communities, with both the public and private sectors investing resources in these initiatives. However, the evidence supporting these practices largely derives from adult observations and interpretations—such as theater reviews, post-performance feedback from teachers, and audience questionnaires. What these methods capture is essentially what adults *perceive* the children to be experiencing, or merely the aspects of the performance that children can recall and articulate after the show has ended.

The issue is that such approaches are ill-suited for elementary school-aged children. Children between the ages of seven and eleven are in what Piaget termed the "concrete operational stage"; while they possess logical reasoning abilities, their reasoning processes still rely on tangible, visible objects [1], [2], [3]. Their engagement with a performance is often expressed physically in the moment—through actions such as pointing at a character, turning to share a reaction with a neighbor, shouting warnings to the protagonist, swaying to the music, or simply letting their attention wander away from the stage. Post-performance questionnaires fail to capture these behaviors, let alone pinpoint exactly when they occurred during the performance.

Consequently, key decisions that determine whether children remain engaged—such as the optimal duration of a dialogue-only scene, the timing of lighting changes, the amount of physical movement required in a fight sequence, or seating arrangements—have long lacked an empirical basis grounded in actual behavioral observation.

Existing Literature

Guo Hongxin points out that drama provides an inclusive and safe space for children to externalize abstract inner emotions [4], Zhang Xiaohua’s research indicates that drama education facilitates children’s self-understanding and communication [5],and Rong Shuhua argues that dynamic visual imagery in theater is key to guiding children’s cognitive development [6]. Approaching the subject from the perspective of playwriting, Liu Dunrui and Gao Xufan explain that the three-act structure itself serves as a technique for sustaining audience attention [7]. While these studies demonstrate that drama impacts children, they do not explain the mechanisms behind this impact.
In her research on young children's social dramatic play, Chen Huiru points out that perspective take is a means by which children understand others [8],meanwhile, Guo Zhaoling and others argue that children are active participants in cultural activities who tend to construct understanding through conversation with others [9] a conclusion also reached by Su Yiru in her discussion of museum exhibition design [10]. Based on this reasoning, child audiences would be expected to process the narrative through social interaction rather than in isolation; however, this hypothesis has not yet been empirically tested against actual behavior observed in the audience.

Chen Li-chou et al, Su Hui-tzu and Chen Jun-qing, and Yeh Jung-hua have each described how children in the concrete operational stage rely on visible elements [1]–[3], Chen Wei-jou noted that children have short attention spans, leading performances to incorporate interaction and dialogue to sustain engagement [11], Lin Mei-chun pointed out that children's appreciation skills evolve from focusing on individual sounds and movements to describing plot and characters [12], Wu Kuan-hsun and Hung Ju-yu conceptualized aesthetic judgment as an intuitive process arising from the interplay between the body and sensory experiences of the real world [13],and Lai Yu-chai analyzed the specific narrative anchor points to which children attach themselves [14].

In summary, while existing research offers mechanisms and theoretical inferences, it lacks empirical measurement. To date, no study has coded the moment-by-moment overt behaviors of child audiences in relation to the dramatic structure of the performance unfolding before them. This study aims to address this gap.

Research Question

The purpose of this study is to understand the behavioral differences exhibited by elementary school children at various stages of a theatrical performance (opening, conflict development, climax, and resolution).

To address this purpose, the study focuses on the following two research questions:
(1) What are the differences in children's behavioral responses across various stages of the storyline (opening, conflict, climax, and conclusion), and what is the distribution of their overall responses?
(2) How do the situations within the story elicit social interaction and participatory behaviors among the children?

Methodology

I. Research Design and Subjects
This study analyzes the behavioral patterns of children while watching theatrical performances. Finding a cooperating troupe proved challenging,the researcher's own affiliation the "Silver Grass Theatre Group " maintains rigorous standards and operates in venues too small for convenient filming. Consequently, the "Circle Children's Theater Troupe" with which the researcher has family ties was selected as the partner for this study. This troupe possesses extensive performance experience and serves a diverse audience, including individuals with disabilities, the elderly, and children in remote areas. To ensure a focused analysis, this study utilizes video footage from the troupe's performances at elementary schools as the primary data source.

II. Segment Segmentation and Behavior Coding
Each performance will be divided into four segments open, development, climax, and conclusion [12]and a behavioral coding scheme comprising six categories will be established:

(a) pointing at a character, (b) sharing with a person nearby, (c) shouting at the stage or alerting the protagonist, (d) lowering the head, (e) nodding or moving to the rhythm, and (f) becoming distracted.

III. Research Ethics
Consent will be obtained from the school and parents prior to recording; the footage is intended solely for this study, will be stored in encrypted form, and will not be distributed externally or publicly released in a manner that reveals identifiable images. There will be no physical contact with any children during the performance, and the venue will be described only in general terms.

Proposal Conclusion

While children's theater has long received public sector support, assessments of its effectiveness have historically relied almost entirely on adult impressions. This study shifts the focus to the children's own behavior, gauging their level of engagement based on what they actually do during the performance rather than on what adults say about it afterward.

2 Another significant contribution of this study is the translation of developmental psychology concepts into actionable design parameters for theater troupes. If sharing behaviors fluctuate with the volume of information presented on stage, and if distraction levels correlate with the duration of the performance, then factors such as total runtime, the ratio of dynamic to static dialogue, the placement of lighting and sound effects, and seating arrangements cease to be matters of subjective judgment, instead, they become variables that can be systematically adjusted and tested. These same tools can also be applied to museum education, classroom presentations, and other live events designed for children.

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